The argument went on, in person, on the phone, for more than a week. He wouldn't let it go.

At one point he actually ordered me, as the Heir speaking to the Spare, to shave.

Are you serious?

I'm telling you, shave it off.

For the love of God, Willy, why does this matter so much to you?

Because I wasn't allowed to keep my *beard.*

Ah—there it was. After he'd come back from an assignment with Special Forces, Willy was sporting a full beard, and someone told him to be a good boy, run along and shave it. He hated the idea of me enjoying a perk he'd been denied.

It also, I suspected, brought back bad memories of being told he couldn't marry in the uniform of his choice.

Then he confirmed my suspicion. He said it outright: In one of our beard debates he complained bitterly about my being allowed to marry in my Household Cavalry frock coat, which he'd wanted to wear for *his* wedding.

He was being ridiculous, and I told him so. But he kept getting angrier and angrier.

Finally I told him flatly and defiantly that his bearded brother was getting married soon, and he could either get on board or not. The choice was up to him.

42.

I SHOWED UP TO my stag ready to party. To laugh, to have a good time, to get clear of all this stress. And yet I also feared that if I got too clear, got too drunk and passed out, Willy and his mates would hold me down and shave me.

In fact Willy told me, explicitly, in all seriousness, *that this was his plan*.

So, while having fun, I was also at all times keeping my older brother in my sight.